

Word family: **sink / sinks / sank / sunk / sinking**

Base word: sink

Past tense: sank

Past participle: sunk

** -ing form:** sinking

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Little by little, the lesson **sank in**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **sink in** means to **gradually become fully understood, realized, or emotionally absorbed**.

The grandfather's lesson did not become meaningful immediately; over time, the speaker truly understood and internalized it.

繁體中文： **某個道理、事實或消息逐漸真正被理解、意識到或深入內心**

中文翻譯：

> “Little by little, the lesson **sank in**.”

「慢慢地，那個教訓才真正**被我理解 / 深入我的心裡**。」

Because **sink in** is essential to the exact target sentence, it should be included even though phrasal verbs are normally excluded by default.

1. **sink = move downward below a surface (下沉) — 下沉；沉下去**

This is the central literal meaning.

Meaning: To move downward, especially below the surface of water or another substance.

Practice 1

> “The stone **sank** to the bottom of the lake.”

「石頭**沉到**湖底。」

Practice 2

> “The boat began to **sink**.”

「那艘船開始**下沉**。」

sink = 因重量、失去浮力等原因向下移動，尤其沉入水面以下

Common:

* sink to the bottom

* sink beneath the water

* ship sinks

2. **sink** = become lower / fall gradually (位置 / 水平) — 下降；降低

Sink can describe something gradually moving to a lower level or position.

Practice 3

> “The sun **sank** below the horizon.”

「太陽**沉到**地平線以下。」

Practice 4

> “The temperature **sank** rapidly after sunset.”

「日落後氣溫迅速**下降**。」

sink = 某個位置、水平、數值或高度逐漸下降

This is a figurative extension of physical downward movement.

3. **sink** = fall into a sitting/lying position (身體) — 癱坐；沉坐

A person can **sink** into a chair, sofa, bed, etc.

Practice 5

> “He **sank** into the chair after the long day.”

「漫長的一天結束後，他整個人**癱坐進**椅子裡。」

Practice 6

> “She **sank** back onto the sofa.”

「她又**沉沉地**坐回**梳化**上。」

sink into something = 身體因疲倦、放鬆、震驚等而慢慢落入坐姿或躺姿

For core counting, I would keep this under the broader **move downward** family.

4. **sink** = decline into a worse condition (狀態惡化) — 陷入；逐漸惡化

Sink can figuratively mean falling into a worse emotional, social, financial, or physical state.

Practice 7

> “He **sank** into depression after the loss.”

「失去那件事後，他**陷入****抑鬱**。」

Practice 8

> “The business gradually **sank** into debt.”

「那門生意逐漸**陷入****債務困境**。」

sink into + negative state = 逐漸陷入較差、較低落或困難的狀態

This is a major figurative development from the idea of moving downward.

5. **sink** = decrease in value, confidence, hope, etc. (下降) — 下跌；低落

Practice 9

> “Share prices **sank** after the announcement.”

「消息公布後，股價**下跌**。」

Practice 10

> “His confidence **sank** after the failure.”

「失敗後，他的信心**大受打擊 / 下降**。」

****sink = 數值、信心、情緒、希望等降到較低程度****

For strict counting, I would merge this with Meaning 2 under the broader ****move/fall downward**** concept.

6. ****sink in = gradually become understood (理解) — 逐漸領悟；真正明白****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 11 — Original

> “Little by little, the lesson ****sank in****.”

「慢慢地，那個教訓才真正**深入我的心裡 / 被我領悟**。」

Practice 12

> “It took a few minutes for the news to ****sink in****.”

「過了幾分鐘，那個消息才真正**讓我反應過來 / 理解**。」

Practice 13

> “His advice did not ****sink in**** immediately.”

「他的建議沒有馬上真正**被理解 / 記入心裡**。」

****sink in = 某個事實、消息、教訓或道理逐漸被真正理解和內化****

This is a fixed phrasal verb and should not be counted as another bare-word meaning of ****sink****.

7. ****sink = be absorbed into a substance (吸收 / 滲入) — 滲入；吸進****

Something can literally ****sink into**** a soft or absorbent material.

Practice 14

> “The rainwater slowly ****sank into**** the dry soil.”

「雨水慢慢**滲入**乾燥的泥土。」

Practice 15

> “Her feet **sank into** the soft sand.”

「她的雙腳**陷入**柔軟的沙中。」

sink into = 向下進入柔軟、鬆散或可吸收的物質中

This helps explain the metaphor behind **sink in**:

> information metaphorically “goes deeper” into the mind.

8. **sink = deliberately destroy a ship by causing it to go underwater (及物) — 擊沉 ; 使沉沒**

Sink can also be transitive.

Practice 16

> “The attack **sank** two ships.”

「那次攻擊**擊沉**了兩艘船。」

Practice 17

> “The damaged vessel was eventually **sunk**.”

「那艘受損船隻最後被**弄沉 / 擊沉**。」

sink something = 使船隻或其他浮在水面的物體沉入水中

This is the causative form of Meaning 1.

9. **sink = defeat or ruin something completely (比喻) — 搞垮 ; 毀掉**

The transitive verb can figuratively mean causing something to fail badly.

Practice 18

> “The scandal **sank** his career.”

「那宗醜聞**毀掉了**他的事業。」

Practice 19

> “One bad decision could **sink** the project.”

「一個錯誤決定就可能**搞垮**整個項目。」

sink something = 令某項計劃、事業、組織等失敗或徹底受挫

This is a figurative extension of **cause to go down**.

10. **sink = basin with water supply/drain (名詞) — 洗手盆 ; 水槽**

As a noun, **sink** has a completely different everyday meaning.

Practice 20

> “The dishes are in the kitchen **sink**.”

「碗碟放在廚房**水槽**裡。」

Practice 21

> “She washed her hands in the **sink**.”

「她在**洗手盆**洗手。」

sink = 廚房、浴室等供洗手、洗東西並設有排水口的盆狀設施

Common:

- * kitchen sink
- * bathroom sink
- * sink tap
- * sink drain

This is clearly a separate noun meaning.

Important distinction: **sink vs fall**

fall

is the broad verb for moving downward.

sink

often suggests:

- * gradual downward movement;
- * going below a surface;
- * descending under weight;
- * figurative decline.

> “The stone fell.”

= 石頭掉下來。

> “The stone sank.”

= 石頭沉下去。

Important distinction: **sink vs drown**

sink

describes an object/person moving downward in water.

drown

means die because of being unable to breathe underwater.

A boat can:

> sink

but it cannot:

> drown

A person can sink without necessarily drowning.

Important distinction: **sink vs drop**

drop

often means a relatively sudden downward movement.

sink

often suggests slower or heavier downward movement.

> “The temperature dropped suddenly.”

> “The temperature sank steadily.”

Both are possible, but the imagery differs.

Important distinction: **sink in vs understand**

understand

simply means grasp the meaning.

sink in

emphasizes that understanding happens gradually and becomes emotionally or mentally real.

> “I understood the words.”

= 我明白字面意思。

> “The meaning finally sank in.”

= 我終於真正領悟到那個意思。

This distinction is exactly relevant to your passage.

Important distinction: **sink vs basin**

sink

is the installed washing fixture.

basin

can mean a bowl-shaped container or, in British English, a washbasin.

So:

> kitchen sink

is much more standard than:

> kitchen basin

Phrasal-verb note

Useful phrasal or multiword forms include:

- * sink in
- * sink into
- * sink back
- * sink down

Under your operating procedure, they are normally excluded unless needed by the target sentence. Here, ****sink in**** is essential, so it must be covered.

Family-extension note

The practical family is relatively small:

- * ****sink****
- * ****sinks****
- * ****sank****
- * ****sunk****
- * ****sinking****

Useful constructions include:

- * sink to the bottom
- * sink below
- * sink into a chair
- * sink into debt
- * sink a ship
- * sink a project
- * sink in
- * kitchen sink

The Golden Manual says grammar-rich words may have small morphological families but still need a broad sweep of literal, figurative, noun, and constructional uses.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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sink — move downward/below a surface	向下移動，尤其沉到水面或其他表面以下
sink — decrease/decline	位置、數值、情緒、信心或狀態逐漸下降
sink into a state	逐漸陷入某種較低落、困難或負面的狀態
sink something	使船隻沉沒，或比喻令計劃、事業等失敗
sink in	某個事實、消息、教訓或道理逐漸被真正理解、領悟或內化
sink — noun	廚房、浴室等用來洗手或清洗物品並設有排水口的水槽 / 洗手盆

For your original sentence

> “Little by little, the lesson **sank in**.”

The exact meaning is:

sink in = 某個道理逐漸從「聽過」變成真正理解、領悟並記在心裡

So:

> **the lesson sank in**

= **那個教訓慢慢真正深入我的心裡 / 我逐漸真正明白了那個道理**

The metaphor fits the passage beautifully:

> information does not stay on the “surface”

> it **sinks deeper** into the mind

For your database, I would count **4 genuinely useful core meanings** for **sink**:

1. **move downward / go below a surface**
2. **decline or fall to a lower level/state**
3. **cause something to sink or figuratively fail**
4. **noun — washing basin / water fixture**

I would keep **sink in** as a major target-specific phrasal expression, merge **sink into depression

/ confidence sank / prices sank** under #2, and merge literal causative **sink a ship** plus figurative **sink a career/project** under #3.